# 5 STUDIO SHORTCUTS

## Your Lecturers Never Taught You

How I won best thesis across engineering, science and architecture.

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# You know that person in studio who just... gets it?

Their concepts are sharp. Their crits go well. They never look like they're dying.

They figured out things that nobody teaches in class. That's it.

Architecture school is a filter. Grading criteria, the design process, how crits work — you're supposed to figure it out yourself. Some people get a good mentor. Most don't.

I spent 6 years doing it the hard way. Then I started writing down what worked. That got me top student in Theory and Professional Practice in the same year, and best thesis across three faculties.

**These are 5 of those shortcuts.**

SHORTCUT #1

# The Grading Rubric Hack

Every architecture school has a grading rubric. Most students never see it. The ones who do rarely use it properly.

DO THIS

1. Ask your tutor for the grading rubric on Day 1 of every project. If they say there isn't one, ask what criteria they'll assess on. (There are always criteria. They just don't hand them out.)
2. Print it. Highlight the top-weighted criteria.
3. For each criterion, write one sentence about how your project addresses it.
4. Before your crit, check each criterion has a visible answer in your presentation.

Most students design based on what they think matters. The students getting top marks design based on what the assessors are looking for. You're not gaming anything. You're just not losing marks on stuff you could easily fix.

**15 minutes per project.**

SHORTCUT #2

# The 3-Concept Rule

Your first concept idea is almost never your best. But most students commit to it because starting over feels like wasted time.

DO THIS

1. After reading the brief, come up with three different concept directions. Not variations of one idea. Three genuinely different approaches.
2. For each one, write a sentence describing the concept, name a reference project that does something similar, and explain why this direction fits the site or brief.
3. Present all three to your tutor at the next desk crit. Ask which one has legs.
4. Run with the strongest. Keep the other two if you get redirected later.

Three options kills the emotional attachment to one idea. Your tutor can point you toward the strongest direction instead of trying to fix a weak one.

**2 hours at the start of each project. Saves 20+ hours of rework later.**

SHORTCUT #3

# The Crit Presentation Formula

Most students present chronologically. "I started here, then I did this, then I changed this." Worst possible format.

PRESENT IN THIS ORDER INSTEAD

1. The problem (30 sec) — What challenge does the brief or site present?
2. Your position (30 sec) — What is your concept, in one sentence?
3. The evidence (2 min) — Show how the concept shows up in your design. Site plan, sections, diagrams. Each one backing up the concept.
4. A question (15 sec) — End with something specific. "I'm trying to resolve the transition between public and private on the ground floor. I'd like your input."

The chronological approach forces your critics to sit there waiting for the point. They get bored and start saying things like "push it further." If you give them the concept first, they can evaluate the work against what you're actually trying to do. The question at the end points their feedback somewhere useful instead of leaving it open.

**30 minutes of re-ordering what you already have.**

SHORTCUT #4

# Site Analysis That Means Something

A sun path diagram, wind rose and some site photos is data collection. It becomes analysis when you say what the data means for your design.

DO THIS

1. For every piece of site data, write one design implication. "Prevailing winds from the southwest" becomes "Orient living spaces northeast, or use the wind for cross-ventilation in summer." "Adjacent building is 4 storeys" becomes "Ground floor in shadow from 2pm. Put daylight-dependent spaces upstairs."
2. Format your page as: LEFT = data/diagram, RIGHT = what it means for the design.
3. Write 3 site-driven design principles at the end.

Your lecturer has seen 10,000 sun path diagrams. The diagram isn't what they're looking at. They want to know if you can turn data into design decisions.

**Add 1 hour to your existing site analysis.**

SHORTCUT #5

# The Weekly Planning System

All-nighters happen because of bad planning. The students pulling all-nighters started their final drawings too late.

DO THIS

1. When you get a project brief, count the weeks to submission.
2. Block the last week for production only. Printing, model photos, layout. No design changes.
3. Block the second-to-last week for final drawings. Design decisions locked by then.
4. Everything before that is design development. Work backwards from the production weeks.
5. Every Sunday night, write down 3 things to finish by Friday. Just 3. Finish those, add more if you can.

You never actually run out of time. You run out of production time. Design fills whatever space you give it, and then there's nothing left for output. If you block production time first, you always hand in finished work. In architecture school, finished-and-decent beats ambitious-and-unfinished.

**20 minutes on the first Sunday of every project.**

# Want the full system?

These 5 shortcuts come from a bigger system I built after winning best thesis.

5 video chapters. Each one covers something architecture school expects you to work out on your own.

- How architecture school actually works (the stuff nobody explains in first year)
- Abstract thinking and creative risk
- Time management, crits and deadlines
- Going from brief to concept (where most people get stuck)
- Site analysis and urban design done properly
- The Konteks Kalendar (weekly planner built for studio)

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